

Cyberbullying

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Introduction



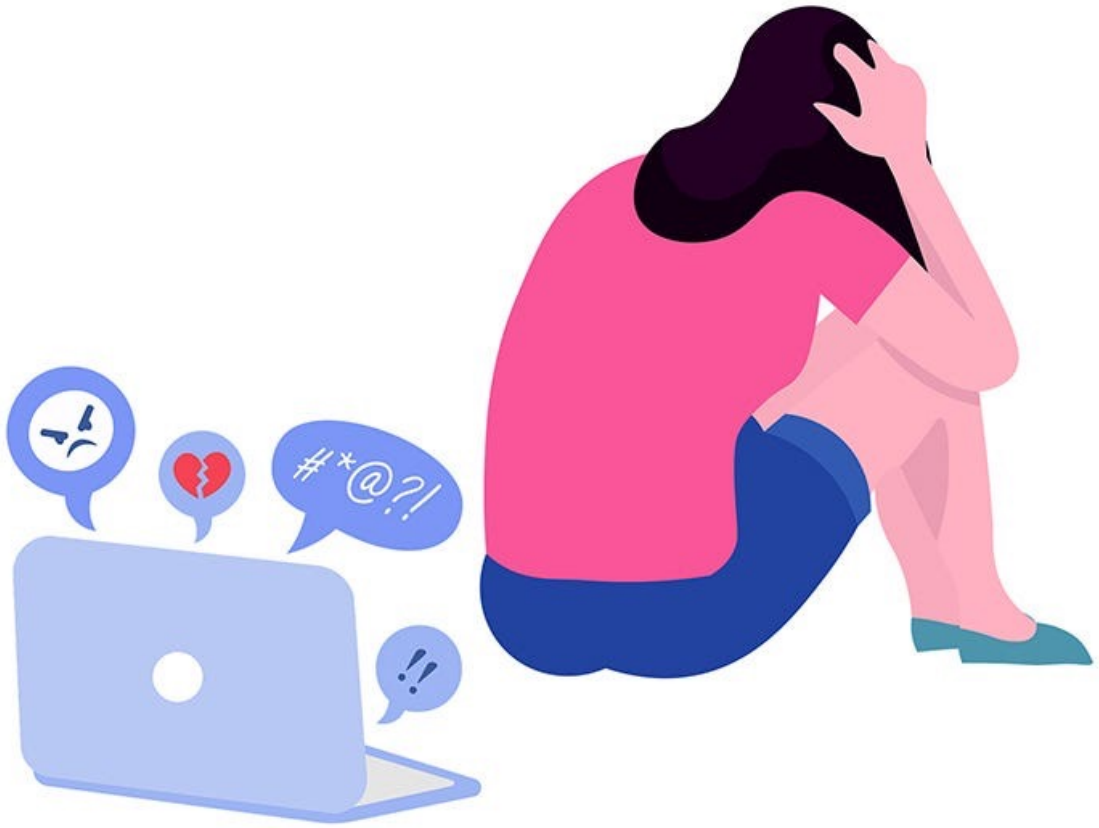
What is Cyberbullying?

- According to Hippo Nation, “Cyberbullying is the use of an electronic communication to bully a person, typically by sending messages of an intimidating or threatening nature” (Hippo Nation)

What is the importance of the topic?

- Cyberbullying affects many people worldwide everyday and can lead to serious mental and emotional health issues; This topic specifically is associated with negative outcomes for those who are bullied including substance use and suicide

Types of Cyberbullying



- Cyberbullying comes in many forms, but here are a few that are frequently utilized:
  - Harassment: repeated, offensive messages
  - Cyberstalking: repeated use of electronic communications to harass or frighten someone
  - Impersonation: pretending to be someone else online
  - Outing: sharing private information or images without consent

Statistics and Prevalence

- Girls are more likely than boys to be victims of cyberbullying, with 34% of girls reporting being harassed online compared to 25% of boys
- 64% of young adults (18-29) have experienced cyberbullying
- Middle school-aged cyberbullying victims are almost twice as likely to attempt suicide than non-victims
- 41% of US adults have experienced some form of online harassment
- The number of Americans experiencing physical threats and sexual harassment online has doubled since 2014

Impact of Cyberbullying

- Effects on mental health: increased risk of anxiety, depression, and suicidal thoughts.
  - Many students involved in cyberbullying experience elevated levels of stress, depression, and anxiety compared to their peers who are not involved in such activities. According to Ybarra and Mitchell (2004), 39% of those who engaged in cyberbullying eventually dropped out of school, while 37% demonstrated delinquent behavior, 32% frequently abused substances, and 16% faced severe depression.
- Impact of academic performance: lower grades and school attendance issues as well as showing lack of wanting to be in a classroom
- Long-Term consequences: difficulty forming healthy relationship with others



Legal and Ethical Aspects

- Cyberbullying can be addressed under civil law or criminal law, based on the severity of it (PrevNet)
  - cases of cyberbullying are more often treated as civil rather than a criminal law matter
  - Some criminal prosecutors have been able to use existing criminal harassment laws to prosecute cyberbullies in public schools. More than half of U.S. states now include "cyberbullying" in their broader bullying or harassment laws. Most states also include a prohibition on "electronic harassment."

  - The ethical issue of cyberbullying:
    - The cyber victims are being humiliated, harassed, and threatened and this causes immense distress to peoples lives with numerous health concerns among young people



Strategies for Prevention

- Ways to manage cyberbullying:
  - Protect accounts and devices
  - Use privacy tools and settings
  - Keep personal stuff private
  - Manage location sharing
  - Teach them to think before posting
  - Conduct a social media audit
  - Log out when using public devices
  - Refuse to respond to cyberbullies
  - Report cyberbullies

Resources for Help

- Cyberbullying Research Center
- StopBullying.gov
- National Suicide Prevention Lifeline



Case Studies – Sara

- Summary:
  - Sara, age 14, has reported being cyberbullied to the school counsellor. She had sent some 'dirty' photos to her 15-year-old boyfriend through Snapchat. He has shown the photos to his friends and now the boys are making fun of her. They are calling her names as she walks by them in the hallway. She has also received 13 Snapchat messages requesting naked pictures of her. The principal and the teachers have not reacted yet but plan to discuss the incident during the teachers' conference next month. None of the other students have been approached about the incident so far.
  - Initial investigation:
    - When Sara reported the incident, the school counsellor took notes of her statement. Since Snapchat deletes shared content after it has been viewed, no record of either the photo or the messages exists. In general, students in the school are very skilled in using social media. Almost everyone has a cell phone and most of the students use Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, Snapchat, Viber and Whatsapp. They use social media for fun, to send photos, videos, to express themselves. Teachers are mostly familiar with social media platforms, more than half of them also have Facebook, Twitter and Instagram profile, some are also using Whatsapp.

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